Grandmother makes plea for reward fund donations in hopes of sparking more leads

By Beth L. Chester
Staff Writer

Saying she fears the trail leading to her grandson's assailant may be growing colder, Levi Frady's grandmother Janice Hamby is asking for the community's financial support to help catch the 11-year-old's killer.

Levi was a sixth grader at North Forsyth Middle School when he was abducted while riding his bike Oct. 22, 1997. He was found shot to death the following day in the Dawson Forest wildlife management area of Dawson County.

Nine months later, Hamby is making a plea for businesses and individuals who have not already pledged contributions to the reward fund to do so. A higher reward might spur new leads in the case, she said.

The reward for information leading to an arrest and conviction in the case has remained at just more than $15,000 since the fund was established shortly after the murder.

Georgia Bureau of Investigation Special Agent-in-Charge Jim Hallman said this week that though he continues to have three agents assigned full-time to the case, the number of viable new leads coming in has greatly decreased.

At this time, Hallman said an arrest in the murder is not imminent.

The veteran agent said he continues to believe Levi's killer will eventually be found. But before investigators can arrest the person or persons responsible, they need any individuals with the remaining pieces of information about the murder to come forward.

A larger reward, officials say, might help to bring those tips to the surface.

Already, more than three dozen Forsyth County businesses and several individuals have pledged $7,000 in contributions.

A $2,000 pledge from the Forsyth County Board of Commissioners and a $1,000 pledge from the Sheriff's Office Crimestoppers unit brings the total from Forsyth County to $10,000.

In Dawson County, two businesses and several individuals pledged contributions to the reward. Five individuals pledged $500 each, with others making contributions between $20 and $250.

The $3,400 from Dawson residents is in addition to the $2,000 initial pledge from the Governor's office.

Danny Hansard, part owner of Klub Kids, a Forsyth County child care center, said their organization made a $100 pledge to the fund last year because they believe it's important for the community to do anything it can do to find justice for Levi.

"If it's possible that something as simple as money would aid in the capture, I'm all for it," Hansard said. "And any human being that has any compassion about this at all — I don't see how they could feel any other way."

Hansard said small businesses which can't make large contributions should pledge as much as they can, realizing numerous $100 donations or less add up to thousands of dollars.

Dawson County business owner Paul Mincey pledged $300 on behalf of 400 Jewelry & Loan. Mincey said he knows first hand the devastation of murder.

Prior to the arrest and convictions of Stephen Mobley for the murder of a Domino's Pizza worker in Oakwood several years ago, Mincey said he was a suspect in that murder. It was Mincey who returned from a pizza delivery to find his co-worker slain inside the restaurant.

Mincey said he pledged a contribution to help find Levi's killer because "anyone who commits cold-blooded murder should be brought to justice." He said he, too, believes somebody knows something about this murder.

As a business owner, Mincey said he donates to a variety of causes and "can't think of anything more important than this."

Levi's grandmother said she and her husband will pledge money saying: "We can't ask anyone else to give until we have given."

Hamby said there is nothing else the family can do for Levi except try to find his killer. She said she also believes an increased reward may help other children as well — by protecting them from her grandson's assailant. In a letter about her request, Hamby wrote, "We can't go on the assumption that it will not happen again. The price is too great.

"You can't keep your children inside all summer, and you can't be with them every minute, and it's not fair that they have to be treated this way. We can't stop all the dangers but we might can stop this one."

She stressed the family's appreciation for all the community has already done. "Levi can't have died for nothing," she said.

Pledges to the reward fund may be made by phone. Contributions will be collected when an arrest is made in the case. Those who want to pledge in Forsyth County may phone Sheriff's Office spokesperson Karlene Chalker at (770) 781-3052. In Dawson County, phone (706) 265-2222.

Dawson County Sheriff Billy Carlisle said he continues to believe Levi's murder was not the act of a random killer passing through the area. "I believe he was killed by someone who knew the Forsyth and Dawson county area very well," he said. That belief is based in part on the fact that Levi was taken to a remote area of Dawson forest.

Others in law enforcement, as well as a spokesperson for the National Center for Missing and Exploited Children, have said it is not common for child abduction murder victims to die as a result of gun shots wounds. Often, when a child is abducted and slain at random, molestation is involved, and victims die from strangulation or other close contact physical abuse.

Authorities still will not disclose whether Levi was molested, saying placing "guilty knowledge" information in the public domain would decrease the credibility of future leads and lessen the evidentiary value of potential statements in the case.

Though Dawson investigators are no longer assigned full time to the case, Carlisle said they continue to assist as needed. Agent Hallman with the GBI said the case will never be closed unless an arrest is made. He confirmed that shortly after the murder, agents ordered the Dawson Forest crime scene area to be clear cut and called in cadets from North Georgia College to assist in a thorough search for clues.

If you have information about Levi's murder, call the Georgia Bureau of Investigation at (770) 535-5423 or the 24-hour hotline at (800) 432-9284. To remain anonymous, write: Levi Frady Case, P.O. Box 229, Dawsonville, Ga. 30534.



Photo/Tom Brooks

Levi Frady's grandmother would like to raise the reward amount in hopes of catching the killer.

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